

Editorial

“Desktop Linux Is An Oxymoron”

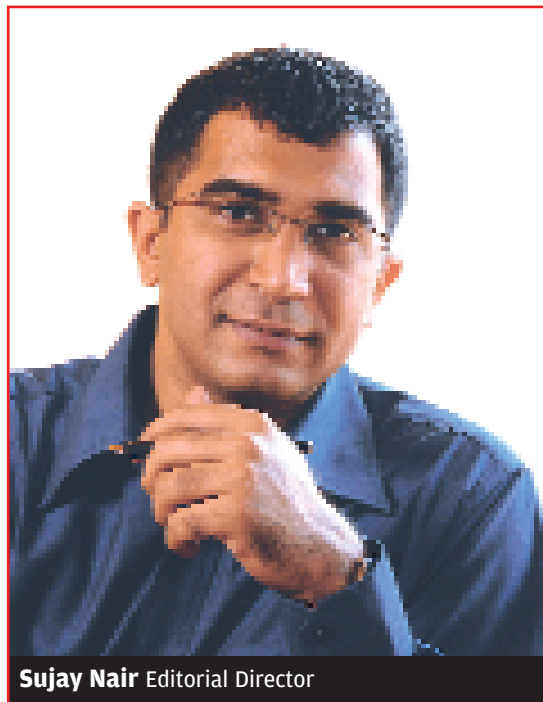
I'M GETTING SICK and tired of certain people complaining about Linux distros, and the difficulties they face when using them. Just to clarify, I'm not talking about the majority, because I usually sympathise with complaints about technology, but when an IT implementer or a “tech freak” says something like “Linux is not ready for the desktop”, it's the last straw. At a recent conference, a very senior security analyst told me that there is no such thing as an “easy-to-use-Linux distro”.

In order to get users to switch an operating system, you have to follow logic. If it's not broken, don't fix it, but if it is, do whatever it takes to fix it. All of us know the advantages of switching to Linux, no viruses, spyware and the resulting crashes. In a professional environment, this leads to a loss of man hours, and worse, a lot of data loss.

So now, in a work environment, Linux begins to sound like OS utopia. This is especially true when you think of the average corporate environment, where a lot of people on PCs need nothing more than a browser, an office suite and a mail client. With software usage restrictions in place, employees are generally not allowed to use much else. Now Linux can do all of this and more, and to be honest, if you never get into the administrative functioning of Windows-lookalike Linux distros, you'd never notice the difference.

Now I'm not stupid enough to suggest that all companies switch *all* employees to Linux. To begin with, you'd have huge problems trying to pry graphics professionals away from their Photoshop machines, and suggesting alternate software to them is likely to earn you a black eye. However, those who don't use Windows-only software for their job roles can easily be ported to Linux. Even if you factor the cost and time of the basic training that's required to get people used to Linux, you'd still end up saving a fortune in OS costs, anti-virus costs, and probably even IT staff costs.

Maybe it's just me, but I don't see any sense in statements like “I've seen, implemented and used Windows for so long, that I know what to expect from it...” To me, this basically translates to, people saying, “I'm so used to anti-virus and anti-spyware software, that I can't imagine life without it.”



Sujay Nair Editorial Director

“...what's really wrong with operating systems is PEBKAC”

Another thing I want to clarify is that this is not one of those popular “Windows-bashing” articles that you will find thousands of. I run Windows XP myself, and it's never crashed on me in 3 years. However, what's really wrong with operating systems is PEBKAC (Problem Exists Between Keyboard And Chair). With millions of malware, sitting on the Net waiting for a gullible user to make just one wrong-click, employees who don't know better are the real problem for IT heads. It takes just one virus to bring down a network, and cause losses in the millions.

The tools to prevent such disasters exist, they're readily available, free, secure, easy-to-use and filled to the brim with features, and yet some of the people whose job it is to find these very solutions spout idiotic tripe like “Desktop Linux is an oxymoron”. Well, you got the “moron” part right sir, but sadly, nothing else.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Sujay Nair'.

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